believed they had the right to hold an entire nation in captivity.

Subsequently, I learned Ambassador Spasowski had been condemned to death by the generals who ruled Poland.

Later that day, I finished writing my speech to the nation; although it was supposed to have been a Christmas message, I decided to deliver a strong message to the Soviets condemning their action in Poland. “We can’t let this revolution against Communism fail without our offering a hand,” I wrote in the diary afterward. “We may never have an opportunity like this in our lifetime.” Then I wrote a message to Leonid Brezhnev condemning the Soviet role in the crackdown in even harsher language; it was sent over the Washington-Moscow cable “hot line,” known in the White House as the “Molink.” I said:

> The recent events in Poland clearly are not an “internal matter” and in writing to you, as the head of the Soviet government, I am not misaddressing my communication. Your country has repeatedly intervened in Polish affairs during the months preceding the recent tragic events. . . . Our two countries have had moments of accord and moments of disagreement. But since [the invasion of] Afghanistan nothing has so outraged our public opinion as the pressures and threats which your government has exerted on Poland to stifle the stirrings of freedom. Attempts to suppress the Polish people—either by the Polish army or police acting under Soviet pressure, or through even more direct use of Soviet military force—certainly will not bring about long term stability in Poland and could unleash a process which neither you nor we could fully control.